

dency to be more self-centred and vindictive after her party's poor performance is reminiscent of erstwhile despots like Idi Amin, Pol Pot and Lenin ("Heartland Battle", August 3). Her commitment towards the cause of the Dalits and the down-trodden was noteworthy, but has been eclipsed now. Mayawati is proving to be a leader with an irrepressible ego.

K.R. VENKATA NARASIMHAN,
Bangalore

Price of Inaction

It is regrettable that many infrastructure projects are either getting delayed or awaiting completion due to red-tapism and vexatious litigations going on against them ("Monuments of Sloth", August 3). These projects demand special attention. Clearing them should top the government's list of priorities.

V.K. TANGRI, Dehradun

Death by Numbers

Hooch tragedies occurring in different parts of the country raise a valid question ("Tippling to Death", July 27). Are state governments not aware of the insidious nexus between bootleggers and the police? The somnolent governments only wake up when hundreds die from consuming cheap alcohol. What we need is a uniform policy at the national level for licensing and marketing safe liquor for the poor.

INDU SHANKAR, Varanasi

Right Track

The Delhi High Court Judgement on Section 377 of the IPC rightly removes the stigma that a gay person is a criminal ("Celebration with Caution", July 20). The rights of gays and lesbians were not directly recognised by any enactment in India. The right to equality that is guaranteed by the Constitution of India also applies to

Tradition", August 3). The common belief that women were barred from learning the Vedas or conducting pujas, however, is wrong. In fact, the Puranas mention that women were taught the Vedas and other scriptures by the rishis.

GVS LAKSHMI, Visakhapatnam

OUR CORRESPONDENT
REPLIES: The report addressed the defiance

YASBANT NEGI



“The Home Ministry should review the parameters that determine VIP security. Only those who face genuine threats should be given adequate protection.”

PREM K. MENON, Mumbai

homosexuals. Under these circumstances, the court gave the right verdict.

K.V. RAMANA MURTHY,
Secunderabad

Sacred Learning

It is heartening to see the progress of the all-girls Sanskrit college ("The Transformation of

of orthodoxy, which goes by a rather rigid interpretation of the Manusmriti. Therefore, while women may or may not have been barred from entering temples in the past, instruction in the sacred texts was kept out of bounds for them by the priestly class.

30
YEARS
AGO IN
INDIA
TODAY

OCTOBER 1-15, 1979

Why US Tilted Towards Pak

Henry Kissinger, 56, the rotund, bespectacled professor of history is considered by most political pundits to have been the most dynamic secretary of state of the United States of America since World War II, and in his heyday was even considered more powerful than the disgraced President Richard Nixon, whom he ably served. Kissinger, in the words of a prominent West European leader, had the most compelling intellect among all men he had ever met. Kissinger possessed an unusual capacity to summarise and analyse lengthy, highly complex negotiating positions without ever referring to notes. Kissinger's intelligence is leavened with an irrepressible wit—a weapon he uses to disarm his opponents and relieve tension. Moreover, as a negotiator, Kissinger was unbeatable because his tremendous stamina enabled him to simply outlast everyone else at the table.



HENRY
KISSINGER

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